2.3 Search results

In this lesson

You will learn:

- how a search engine shows the links it finds.

How many pages?

The web contains 1.9 billion websites. Whatever question you ask, a search engine will find many matching pages.

When a search engine shows a list of links it includes the total number of pages it found. The search shown in this image has found 722,000,000 results.



You can make the list shorter by adding more key words to a search. However, you do not usually need to do this.

How a search engine sorts results

A search engine tries to put the most useful links at the top of the list of results. It uses several methods.

- **How popular is a page?** The most popular web pages are shown on the first page of search results. A page is popular if many other sites link to it.
- **How up to date is a page?** Web pages that change often are shown near the top of the search results. Adding new information to a web page is called updating.
- **Can the website be trusted?** Websites that a search engine trusts are shown near the top of the results. This does not mean that you can believe everything you see on websites near the top of the list. You still need to check the facts.

- **Which pages have you looked at before?** A web browser keeps a list of websites you have looked at. The search engine uses this information to predict which websites you will want to see in the future.

Adverts

Most search engines show adverts at the top of the list of results. The owners of these websites pay for the adverts. Adverts are not always relevant to your search.



Meta tags

The owner of a website wants the world to see their pages. One way they can do this is to use **meta tags**. Meta tags are like key words. They are single words that describe a web page.

Web developers add meta tags to the pages they create. People who read a web page cannot see the meta tags, but search engines can see them. If any key words in your search question match the meta tags on a web page, the search engine shows that page near the top of the results list.



Activity

Carry out another web search about Tungurahua. How many results does the search return? Add some more key words to your search. What happens to the number of results?



Extra challenge

How many adverts are shown when you search for Tungurahua? What are the adverts for? Do the adverts give you any useful information?

Think again

Carry out a web search for more information about how search engines work. How many adverts are at the top of the list of results? How many of the adverts give you useful and relevant information?

2.4 Choosing web content

In this lesson

You will learn:

- how to choose information carefully from the world wide web.

Can you trust web content?

A web search will provide you with links to many web pages. The links lead to information you can use to complete a project. How will you decide which web pages to use and which to reject?

Sometimes content on web pages is wrong. The person who wrote the content may have made a mistake or the information may be out of date. Sometimes the writer of a web page may deliberately try to mislead you.

Checklist for choosing web content

Ask the questions in this checklist to help you to choose content that is correct, reliable and relevant.

1 Who wrote the content?

Who owns the website? Websites that belong to governments, charities, universities or other large organisations are usually reliable sources of information.

Who wrote the web page? It is a good sign if the writer has included their name on the web page. Sometimes web pages also include the writer's job title and contact details.



2 Is the content up to date?

Can you find the date when the web page was last updated? Having up-to-date information is important. It is very important in computer studies because technology changes quickly. It can be less important for subjects like history and mathematics.

3 Is the page appropriate for your age?

Content: Can you understand the content or is it too complicated for you? Is there more detail than you need? Is the content too simple for you?

Language: Are there too many words that you don't understand? Are the sentences too long? This is especially important if you are reading content in a second language.

4 Is the content relevant?

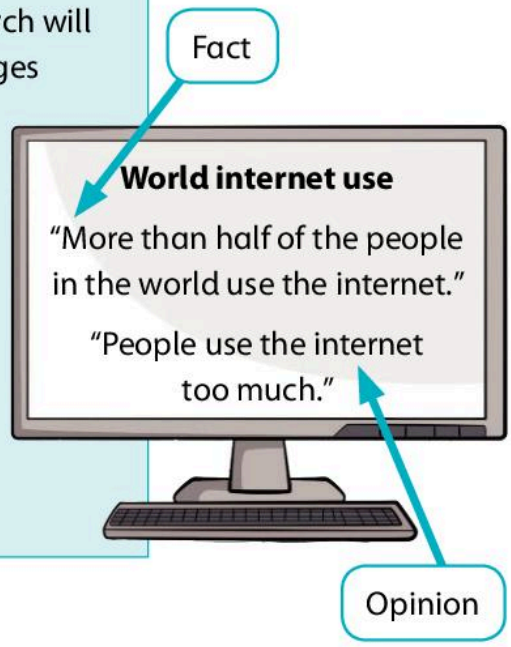
Does the page answer your search question? A web search will find many interesting and well-written pages. Which pages provide the information you need?

5 Does the page give you facts or opinions?

Facts: A fact is something that you can check to find out if it is true.

Opinions: An opinion is a what someone thinks or feels.

Does the page give you facts to help you to make up your own mind? Or is the writer giving their opinion to try to persuade you to agree with them?





Activity

Choose a web page you have visited during this unit. Use the checklist in this lesson to write a report about the page.



Explore more

Ask a member of your family to suggest a web page you can both look at. Working together, complete the checklist shown on this page. What does your family member think of the website? Good or bad?



Extra challenge

Search the web for information about the impacts of climate change. Find a page that you like. Is the page mainly facts or opinions? Give one example of each.